

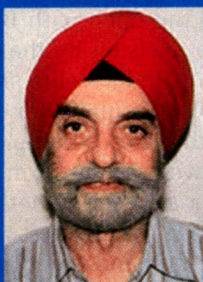
bles, this after he'd already won the quota place following his world championship win in Zagreb. Still wonder why he is steaming now? Singh though wonders why Bindra didn't directly ask for an exemption. He says his friendship with the family has involved reciprocal visits between homes and tries to calm all feathers. "Results will be the criteria. Suma will be in the team. I will accommodate everyone." As if shooters are party faithfuls seeking tickets for municipal elections.

Shirur says decisions of the kind she has endured, "pull you back again and again". Indian shooters these days were, she said, "getting more and more professional. We just wanted to be treated professionally."

Let us count the ways. In the past NRAI sent the most curious of "coaches" with World Cup teams: Jagjit Singh, relative of Baljit Singh Sethi, secretary-general of the NRAI,

Dubious Distinction

It's not just about dropping bombs on ace shooters; violating legal norms also features on the list of NRAI's disorders



SETHI, IN A TOP NRAI POST FOR 25 YEARS

The NRAI's problems are not merely related to shooters, but expand to include its very functioning. A sessions court in Delhi has ticked off the NRAI for fielding officials for holding office for more than two consecutive terms and ordered them to surrender office. The officials involved are president Digvijay Singh (president for 10 years) and Baljit Singh Sethi (in his 25th year as secretary-general). The Directorate of Revenue Intelligence has slapped down a Rs 8-crore fine on the NRAI for allegedly selling ammunition to state units at a profit. The Delhi High Court has admitted a PIL from a sports enthusiast lawyer Rahul Mehra, asking the court to investigate the functioning of sports federations, including the NRAI, accusing them of mismanagement, lack of transparency and accountability, and a flawed electoral process which has officials holding key posts for endless terms.



“Results will be the criteria. I will accommodate everyone. As a democrat, I am prepared to resolve all problems.”

DIGVIJAY SINGH, NRAI PRESIDENT

“We need to restructure the selection process for shooting to make it logical, transparent and fair.”

MORAD ALI KHAN, GOVERNMENT OBSERVER



and Sushil Choudhary, father of female shooter Shagun Choudhary, went to a World Cup in Lonato. The "handling charges" offered as a reason by the NRAI to tax officials for charging an alleged premium on its customs duty-exempt ammunition are handled by a taxi/transport company owned by a senior NRAI official. Last year, a few shooters received phone calls asking them to donate funds to an NRAI official's election campaign. When under public scrutiny, the NRAI digs out mobile phone records of shooters they suspect of 'leaking' information.

Coaches involved with the elite shooters want the selection criteria to

be restructured but cannot say so in public for fear of inviting NRAI's pistol-whip. Professionalism obviously belongs to another planet.

The selection trial is a mandatory exercise in other countries which also have organised training and coaching programmes and world class facilities. The best federations are involved in policy, and execution is handled by clubs. The NRAI holds both policy and execution in iron fists and the selection trial has become a demonstration of power and control.

The ranges in Pune don't have running water in their toilets and those in Patiala had trap machines that broke down and misfired. When

shotgun shooters complained, an NRAI official told them they really didn't know how to shoot.

Khan, involved in many discussions with the NRAI as a shooter and now a government observer, says the association will be meeting soon to address issues and expects elite shooters' problems to be solved. "We need a restructure of the selection process to make it fair, transparent and logical." Just like its elite have, more needs to change in the administration of Indian shooting, starting with its officials. Most countries separate the head coach's function between those in charge of pistol and rifle and those in charge of shotgun. Some countries have separated the federation into two parts itself centred around the different disciplines.

Bindra leaves for Germany in a few days and will shoot in his first major competition this year. He is uncertain of how the year will pan out. "The only thing I want now is to see a positive change in Indian sport." Then the lone wolf in him growls: "I'd rather die as a rebel." This is the worst reflection of Indian sports administration. After all, who threatens its own champions with bullets? ■